

Case Study

The year is 1894.

Worcester manufacturers are well organized, united, and anti-union. Their local residency, civic responsibilities, and paternalistic policies make them less vulnerable to resistance from organized labor compared to capitalists in other industrial cities. In addition, solidarity among industrialists, rooted in informal social and business networks, keeps Worcester's large employers strong. Industrialists mobilize against labor unions by creating local trade groups, such as the National Metal Trades Association (NMTA), which effectively rallies employers and the general public against unionization and maintains a citywide blacklist to drive out suspected organizers. Public schools even censor teaching about unions or economics.

At the same time, the workers are segmented into dissimilar occupations and trades, making it difficult for them to perceive themselves as part of a common working class. Ethnic and religious differences further fragment the labor force, inhibiting communication and the development of shared goals. Faced with these barriers, Worcester workers do not develop radical politics and activist trade unions, and they do not organize the worker strikes that are spectacular events in other U.S. cities.

For unskilled laborers, wages range from \$1.25 to \$2.00 dollars per day, with a typical workday of ten hours or more. In addition, working conditions in factories and outdoor labor are unhealthy and often dangerous. Labor unions are few and weak, particularly in Worcester. Although workers in other industrial cities commonly orient themselves around trade unions or political organizations, in Worcester only 10% of the workforce belongs to a union. Here, the working people organize themselves around ethnic communities, which give them a culturally familiar environment but discourage class solidarity and activism. Factory workers remain divided along ethnic lines.

Worcester's economy, though, is booming: the value of the city's manufactured products has leaped from \$1M to \$5M between 1837 and 1855. This trend continues to rise each year, and now, available jobs outnumber unskilled workers. The laborers should understand that they have options.

Worcester, Massachusetts, is expanding its sewer lines in the College Hill neighborhood. The plan is to extend the trunk sewer in Southbridge Street to Stearns Square. This construction must cross the Blackstone River, requiring the use of an inverted syphon about 125 feet long, constructed of 24-inch cast-iron water pipe with lead joints. The pipe must be laid with a slight grade (1 foot in 500 feet) in the direction of the flow. It will be connected with the brick sewer at each end by means of a manhole.

The manhole at the lower end has a sump six inches deep to catch any solids that might otherwise obstruct the syphon. The water-line at the middle of the iron pipe will be 6.5 feet below the natural grade of the sewer at that point. The pipe will come two feet into the abutment of the bridge at the upper end, and it will clear the bed stone of the other abutment at the lower end. The pipe will run beneath the bed of the stream throughout. At this location only, work must be done at night and on Sundays to avoid the high water caused by wheels from the mills above. Lights will be placed to facilitate night time work.

Harrison P. Eddy, Worcester's Superintendent of Sewers, is ultimately responsible for keeping the cost of this project within budget. He answers to the City Engineer, the Mayor, the Common Council, and the Council Members who sit on the Committee on Sewers. All of these men are in turn responsive to Worcester's many industrialists and other leaders, who want to see street improvements but are nervous about the expense of all the sewerage construction that has taken place in the past few years. Fortunately, the cost of pipe sewers has dropped since last year from \$.72 per foot to \$.59 per foot, so that when the city's budget for this project was approved last year, the cost of pipe was higher than it is now. Worcester can take advantage of this savings in pipe material.

The city needs to hire laborers to dig the ditch before the pipes are laid. The project requires 1956 feet of ditch along the following streets: Southbridge Street, College Avenue, and Caro Street. The city's budget for this project includes not only the cost of labor (unskilled ditch-diggers, more skilled pipe-layers, plumbers, and foremen), but also the cost of materials: cast iron for the water pipes, lead for the joints, brick for the connecting sewers at each end, a man-hole, syphon, lights, and so on. To seek cheaper materials would be to risk buying inferior goods that won't hold up over time. However, unskilled labor is one area in which the city can keep costs low.

The streets are still piled high with snow, but in a few short weeks the thaw will set in, and once the snow is cleared and the land begins to soften, it will be time for the project to begin. Both sides are eager to begin work as soon as conditions permit. The project will likely take 9-10 months to complete. Worcester officials hope it can be finished before the most disruptive snowfalls begin in December.

The Labor Community in Worcester has its own interests to protect. The Worcester Central Labor Union, which unites different labor unions in support of common causes, is working to bring a 54-hour workweek bill (9 hours/day x 6 days/week) to the Massachusetts State House. Since 1886, workers around the country have been agitating for a shorter workday at the same daily wages. In a number of places, they have been successful. Massachusetts has a 10-hour law, but in Worcester it is not enforced and most workers don't have the status to insist on their rights. Many laborers in Worcester still work 12-14 hour days.

Worcester has never been very friendly to organized labor. P.J. McGuire, founder of the Carpenter's Union and a prominent leader in the American Federation of Labor, called Worcester "one of the scab holes of the state" (1889). Unlike some states, Massachusetts has no law prohibiting blacklisting, so an unruly employee who complains too harshly may be blacklisted and kept from other employment in the city. Although many of them are self-made men, most of the city's industrialists have little sympathy for the recent immigrants who perform the city's most difficult labor. They often attribute the anger of a laborer to spleen produced by excessive drink. Many industrialists believe that the Irish men who dig ditches are not likely to spend extra money very wisely. These men are much more likely to buy liquor than books or a sewing machine, so why worry about an extra hour here or there?

Last year, Worcester paid its ditch diggers \$.15 per hour for a 10-hour workday, 6 days per week. In spite of sewer construction projects throughout the city, Worcester's winters limited this work to 44 weeks of the year, and that remains generally true of this kind of work. A typical laborer employed by the city to dig ditches earns only about \$396 per year, which is inadequate to cover the cost of a typical family. Therefore, a laborer must send his wife or children out to work to supplement his income as the head of household. Even when a daughter works as a domestic servant or a son finds work in a factory or as a delivery boy, these families eke out only a meager existence, with most of their expenses going to rent, fuel, and coarse food.

Negotiation Setting:

The Worcester Central Labor Union is meeting in three days with the City of Worcester to negotiate a contract for the expansion of sewer lines in the College Hill neighborhood.

Negotiation Characters:

Team A will represent the Worcester Central Labor Union.

Each member in Team A may take up any two of the following characters. If your team has three members, assign one character each.

Worcester laborers representatives:

1. Amsted Jackson
2. Dr Robert Booth
3. Senator George

Negotiating for the Worcester laborers: Some background information

Not all three characters representing Worcester laborers are wage laborers, but all of them share concerns about the welfare of ordinary working people. Jackson, an African American machinist working for the Blaisdell Company, a maker of machinists' tools, is the most directly interested in fair wages. Booth, a family doctor living downstream from Worcester, retains strong sympathies for wage laborers because of his earlier experiences working in a woolen factory. Senator George, a Worcester native, has long been a champion for slaves, freedmen, and working people.